

Guide

NVivo to Thematic Analysis

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Purpose of the guide



This guide provides practical guidance for using NVivo to organize, code, explore and manage qualitative research data.

It is designed for researchers working with qualitative data such as interviews, focus groups, or open-ended responses.

The guide introduces the main principles of thematic analysis and explains how NVivo can support each stage of the analytical process.

Important: NVivo is a software tool that supports qualitative data analysis. It does not perform the analysis or determine which themes should be identified. Analytical decisions remain the responsibility of the researcher.

1. Understanding Thematic Analysis

1.1 What is Thematic Analysis?

Thematic analysis is a qualitative research method used to identify, analyze and help to interpret patterns of meaning, or themes, within qualitative data.

It can be used to explore participants' experiences, perceptions, opinions and representations...

A thematic analysis generally involves moving from the raw data towards increasingly structured interpretations:

Raw data → Codes → Categories → Themes → Interpretation

1.2 Different Approaches to Thematic Analysis

Thematic analysis can be conducted using **different methodological approaches**. These approaches may differ in their assumptions about the role of the researcher, coding, interpretation and the identification of themes.

For example, Braun and Clarke's approach to thematic analysis recently provides and update their structured framework for developing themes from qualitative data (Braun & Clarke, 2021).

However, thematic analysis is not a software-specific method. **NVivo** can be used to support different qualitative analytical approaches. The software does not determine the methodology. The methodological approach should therefore be defined before or alongside the analytical process, according to the research question and study design.

1. Understanding Thematic Analysis

1.3 An Overview

A simplified thematic analysis workflow can be represented as:

01 — Familiarize

Read and re-read the data.

02 — Code

Identify meaningful segments of the data and assign codes.

03 — Organize

Group related codes and identify broader patterns.

04 — Develop themes

Review and refine patterns into meaningful themes.

05 — Interpret

Relate the themes to the research question and existing literature.

06 — Report

Present the findings using supporting excerpts from the data.

Remember: The process is iterative.

Researchers may move back and forth between stages as their understanding of the data develops.

2. Understanding NVivo

2.1 What is NVivo ?

NVivo is qualitative data analysis software designed to help researchers organize, code, classify, retrieve and explore qualitative data.

NVivo can be used with **different types of qualitative material**, including:

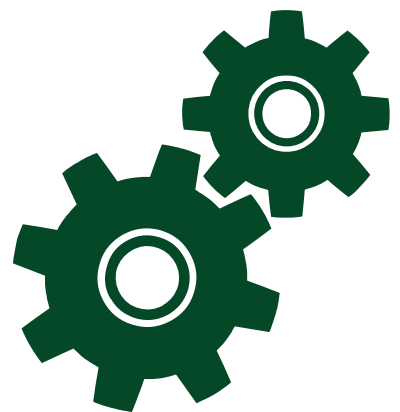
- Interview transcripts
- Focus groups
- Documents
- Audio and video files
- Images
- Open-ended survey responses

The software **facilitates** the management of large amounts of qualitative data and provides **tools** for exploring relationships and patterns within the dataset.

2.2 What NVivo Can and Cannot Do

NVivo can help you:

- ✓ Organize qualitative data
- ✓ Create and manage codes
- ✓ Retrieve coded excerpts
- ✓ Compare data across participants or groups
- ✓ Explore patterns and relationships
- ✓ Visualize aspects of your dataset
- ✓ Keep track of your analytical process
- ✓ Export coded data and results

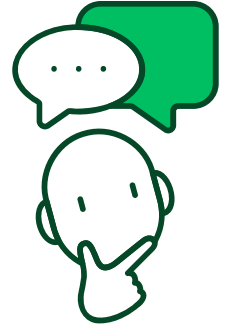


2. Understanding NVivo

2.2 What NVivo Can and Cannot Do

NVivo cannot:

- ✗ Decide what your research question should be
- ✗ Determine the meaning of participants' statements
- ✗ Automatically identify the "correct" themes
- ✗ Replace the researcher's interpretation
- ✗ Guarantee the quality of the analysis



2.3 Key Concepts and Terminology

Before using NVivo, it is useful to understand a few key concepts.

- **Source:** A document or file imported into NVivo for analysis.
- **Code / Node:** A label used to identify a meaningful segment of data.
- **Coding:** The process of assigning a code to a segment of data.
- **Case:** A unit of analysis, such as a participant, couple, patient or organization.
- **Attribute:** Information describing a case, such as age, group, gender or time point.
- **Theme:** A broader pattern of shared meaning identified across coded data.

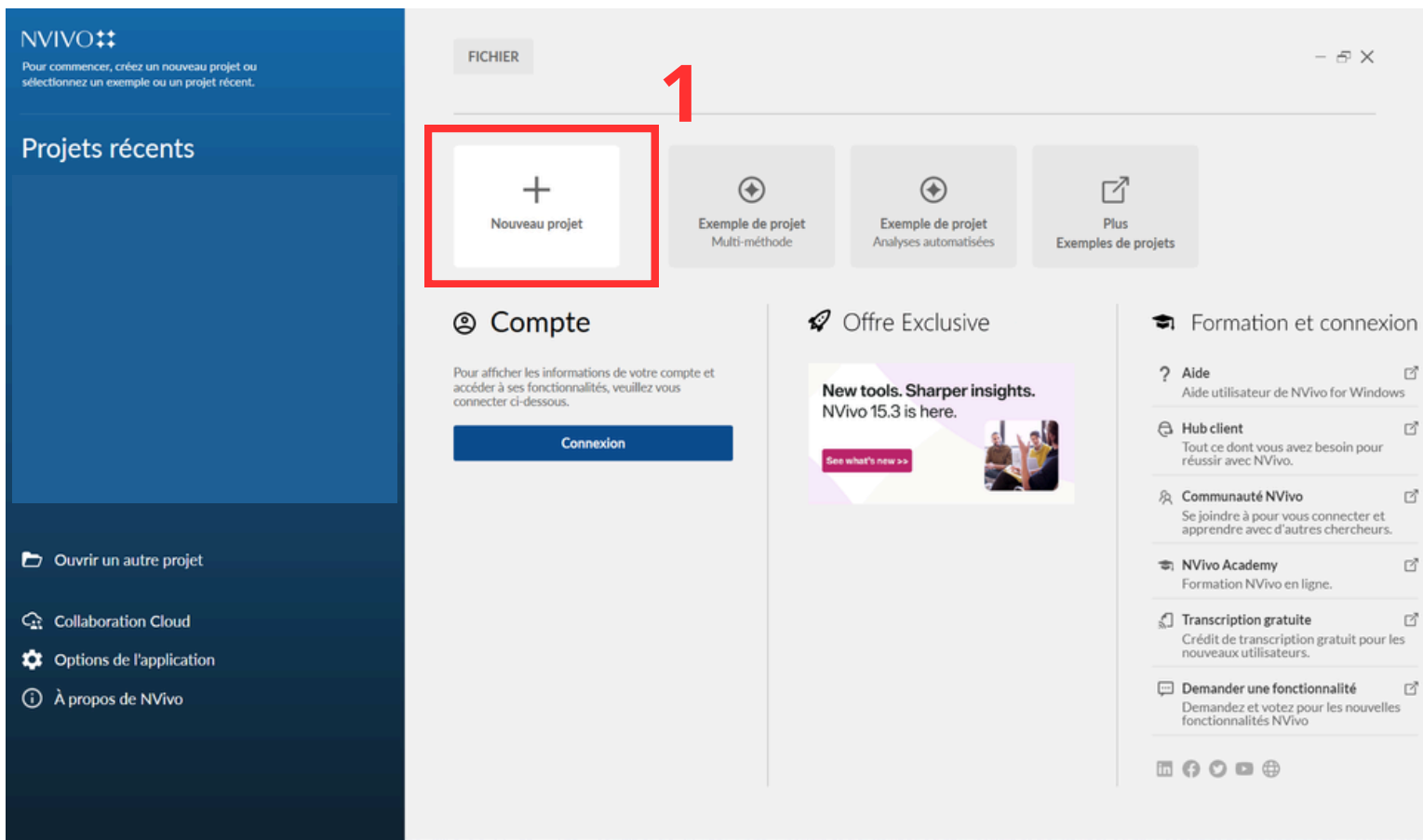
*Terminology may vary depending on the version of NVivo being used.
NVivo 13 is used for this guide*

3. Getting Started with NVivo

3.1 Creating a New Project

- **1.** Open NVivo and select New Project.
- **2.** Enter a clear and identifiable project name.
- **3.** Choose an appropriate location for the project file.
- **4.** Select the language of your data
- **5.** Choose parameters concerning save and documents recuperation

Tip: Save the project in a dedicated research folder and make regular backups.



3. Getting Started with NVivo

3.1 Creating a New Project

NOUVEAU PROJET - ÉTAPE 1 de 2

Les projets créés dans cette version de NVivo ne peuvent pas être ouverts dans une version antérieure à 1.6.

Titre du projet

Nom de fichier

Description

(Optionnal : add description if needed)

☐ Conservez un journal des actions des utilisateurs

Pour l'analyse textuelle de vos données, sélectionnez la langue du contenu textuel dans laquelle seront (la plupart de) vos fichiers de données.

Langue du contenu textuel

Anglais (États-Unis)

Annuler Suivant

NOUVEAU PROJET - ÉTAPE 2 de 2

Sauvegarde de projet

Enregistrer automatiquement le projet ? (Si oui, Annuler est désactivé)

Afficher les rappels de sauvegarde tous les

Récupération de projet

NVivo peut créer automatiquement des fichiers de récupération de projet en tant que sauvegardes à court terme. La création de fichiers est déclenchée par l'enregistrement. (Nous vous recommandons également d'enregistrer les sauvegardes manuellement)

Créer des fichiers de récupération

Stocker le plus récent

Emplacement du fichier de récupération

Précédent Créer un projet

3. Getting Started with NVivo

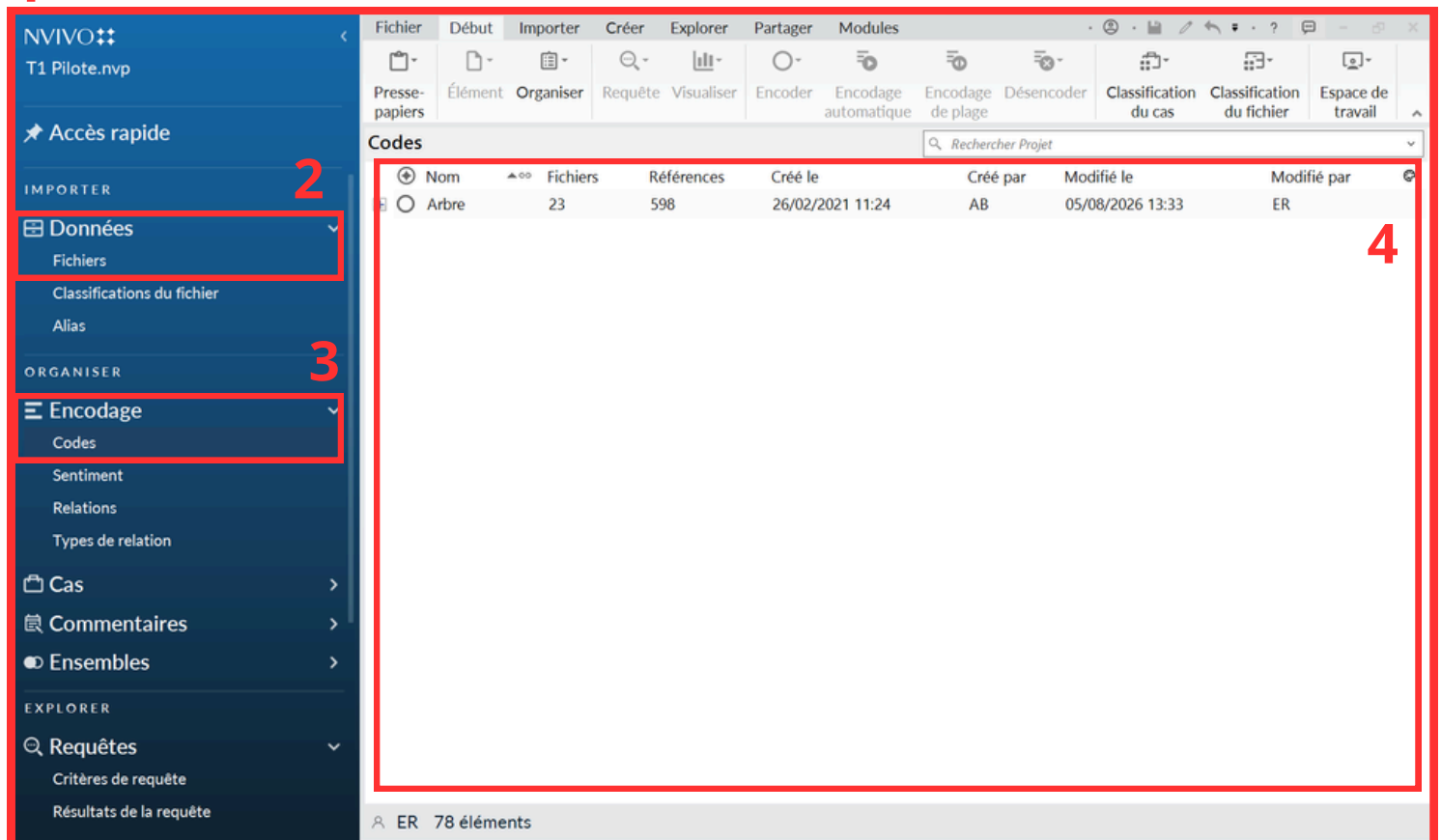
3.2 An Overview of the Interface

The NVivo interface is organized into several main areas. Depending on the version of NVivo, you may find:

- **1: Navigation area:** access different sections of the project
- **2: Sources:** access imported data
- **3: Nodes / Codes:** manage your coding structure
- **4: Coding:** view and work with selected content
- **5: Queries:** explore coded data and relationships
- **6: Visualizations:** represent aspects of your data
- **7: Exports:** export your data

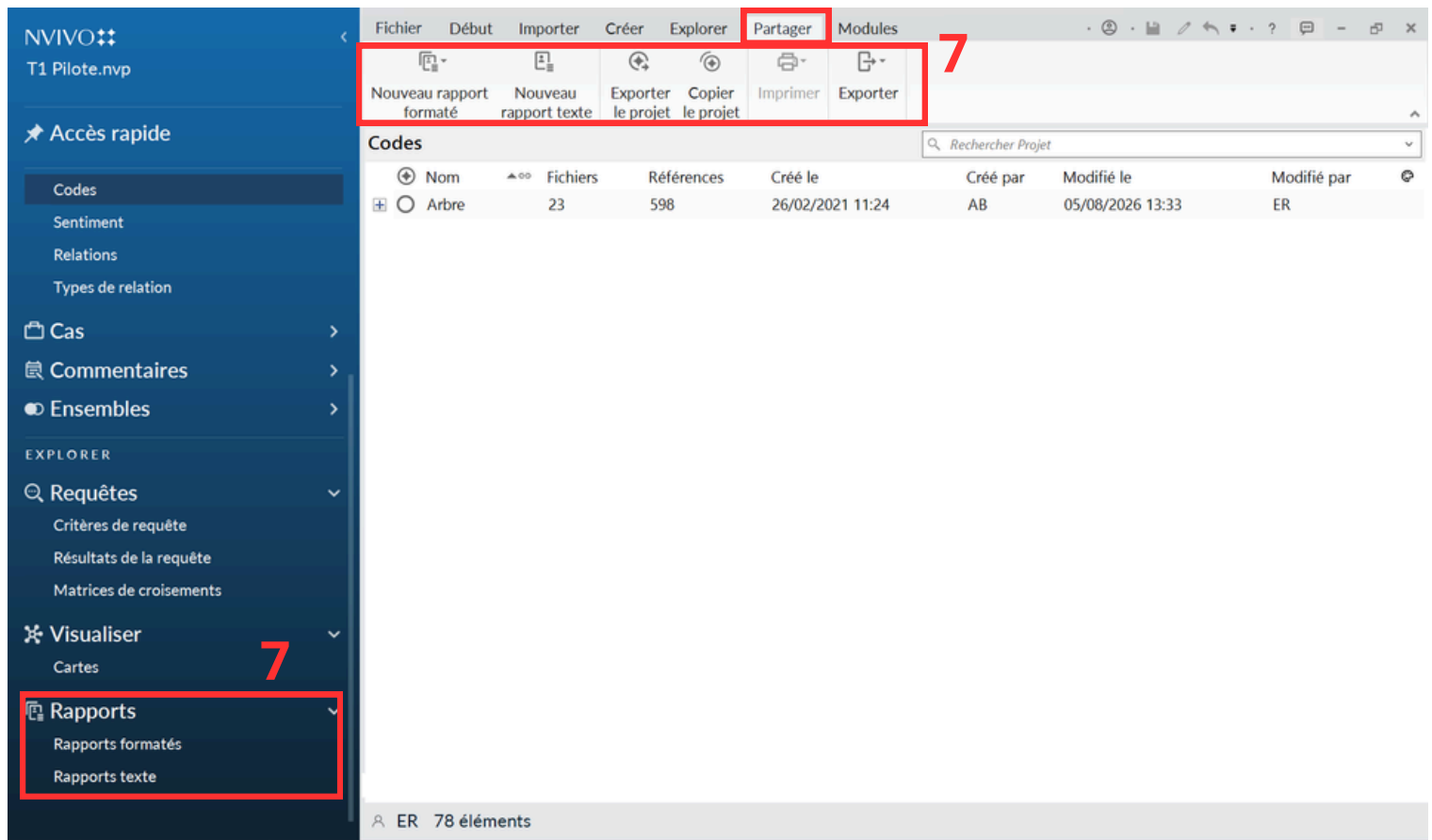
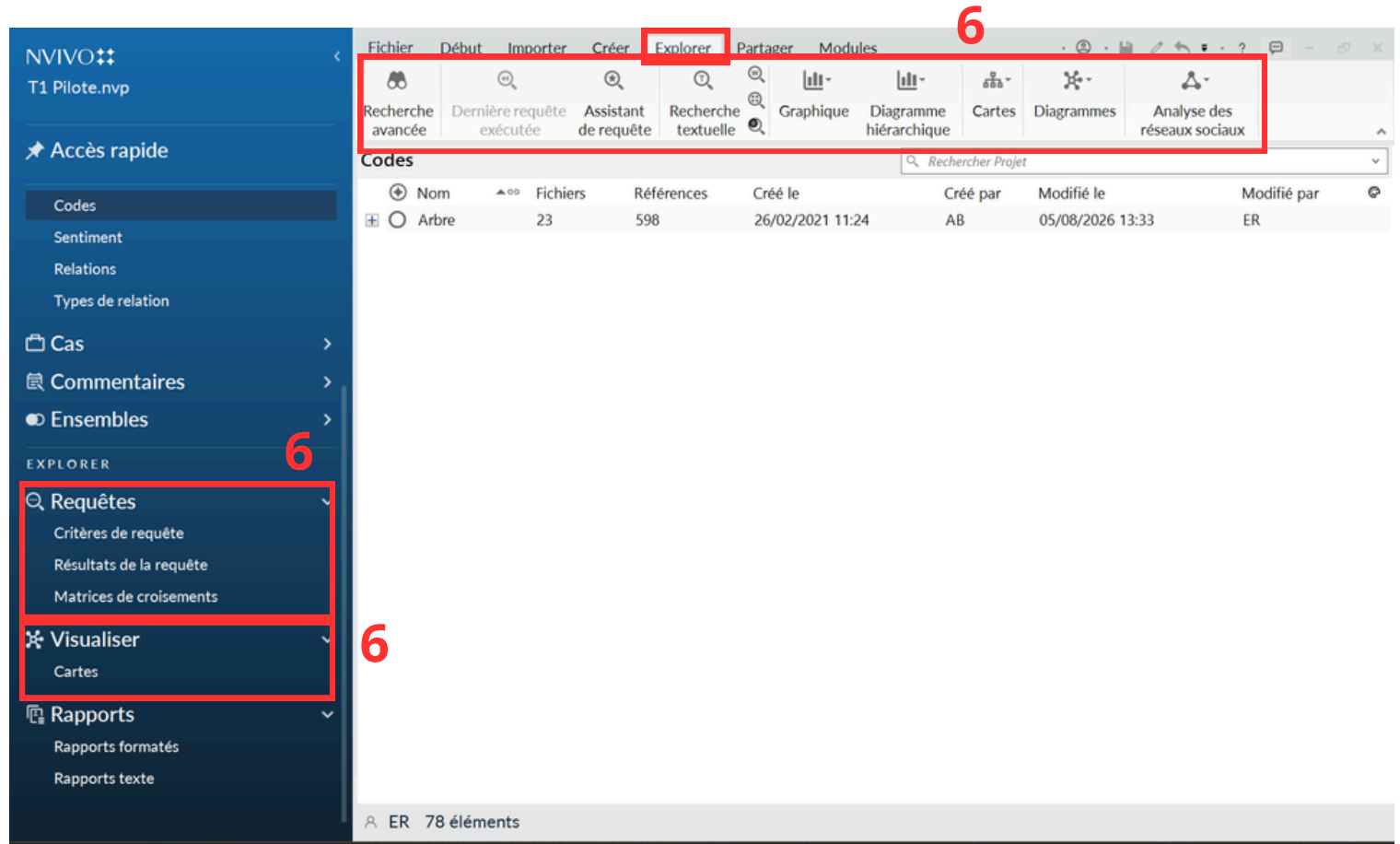
Tip: The exact appearance of the interface may vary depending on the NVivo version.

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3. Getting Started with NVivo

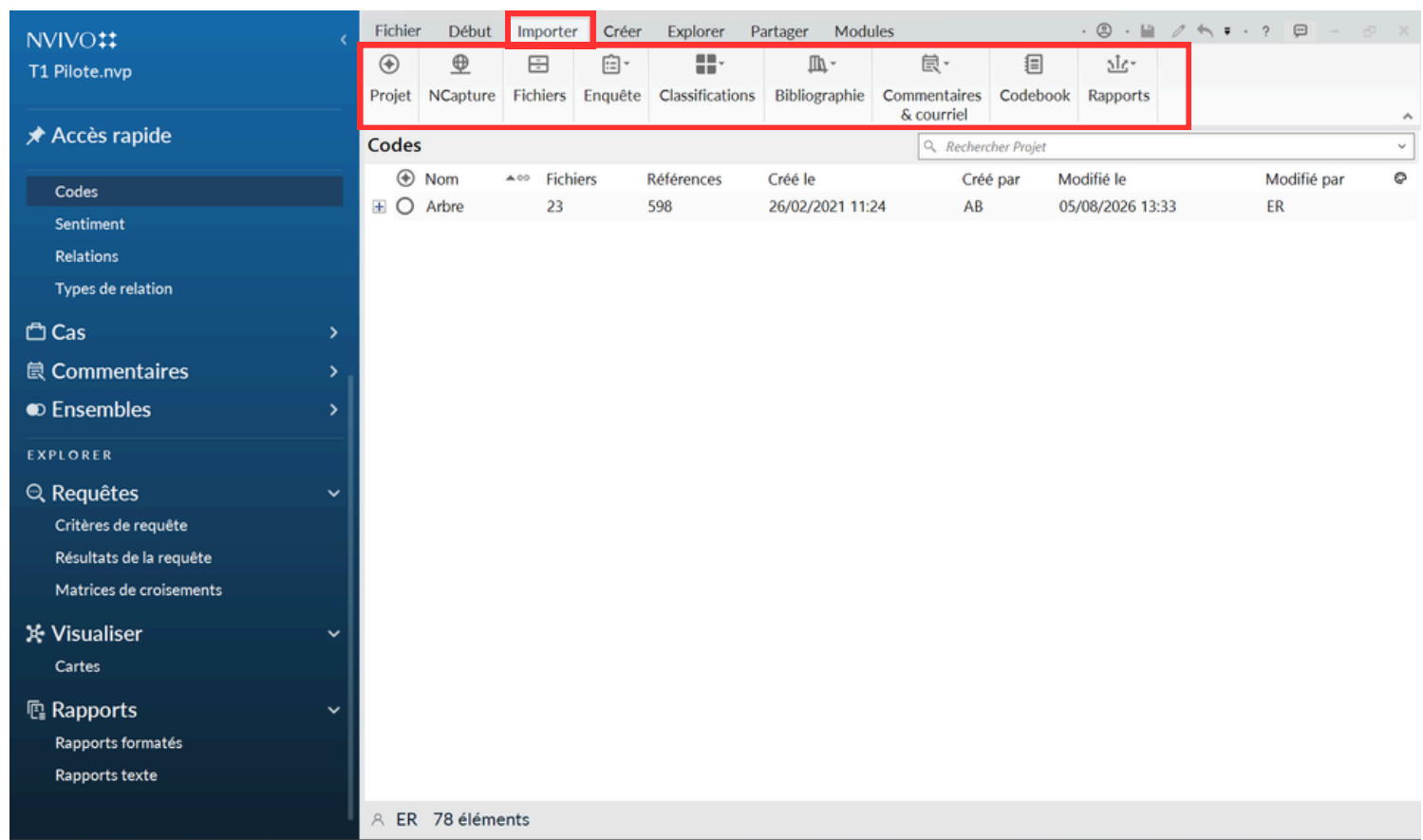
3.2 An Overview of the Interface



4. Importing interviews

To import your data:

- Select Import.
- Choose the files you want to import.
- Check that the files have been imported correctly.
- Organize the sources within the appropriate folders.



5. Coding your data

5.1 What is a Code?

A code is a short label that captures the meaning or content of a segment of data.

For example:

"Since the intervention, we communicate more easily."

Possible code → Improved communication

Codes should be sufficiently specific to capture meaningful information while remaining useful across the dataset.

5.2 Creating and Managing Codes

In NVivo, codes are commonly organized as **nodes**. You can create a new code when you identify a meaningful concept in the data.

When creating a code, consider:

- Is the code relevant to the research question?
- Is the label clear?
- Does the code capture one meaningful idea?
- Could the same code be applied to similar excerpts elsewhere?

Tip: Avoid creating a new code for every slightly different wording of the same idea.

5. Coding your data

5.2 Building a thematic tree

Themes are developed by identifying broader patterns of meaning across the data.

For example:

Codes

More dialogue

Better listening

Fewer arguments



Category

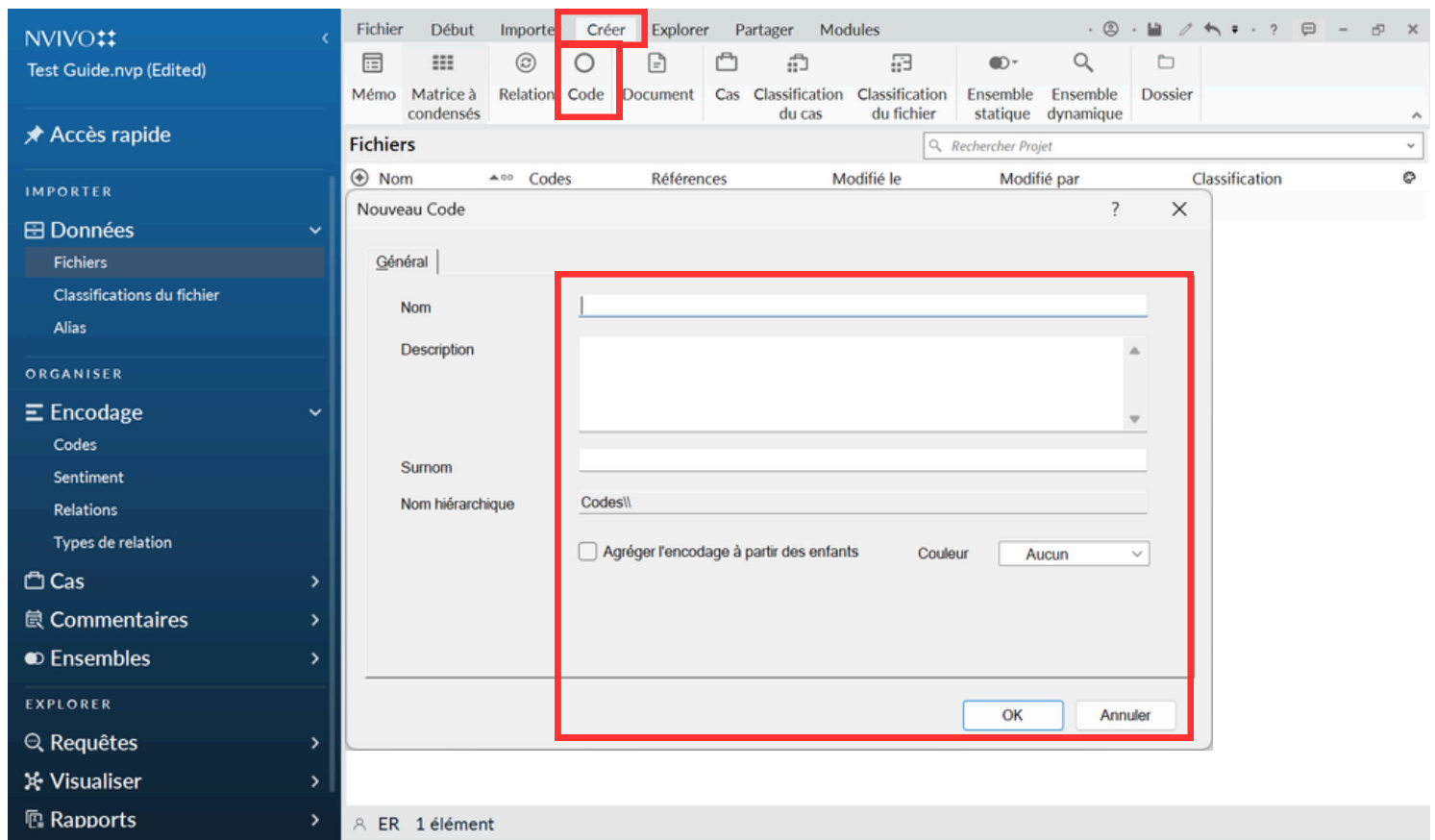
Communication changes



Theme

A more harmonious relationship

Important: A theme should be analytically meaningful, not simply a collection of frequently occurring codes.



5. Coding your data

5.2 Building a thematic tree

NVIVO

Test Guide.nvp (Edited)

Accès rapide

IMPORTER

Données

- Fichiers
- Classifications du fichier
- Alias

ORGANISER

Encodage

- Codes
- Sentiment
- Relations
- Types de relation

Cas

Commentaires

Ensembles

EXPLORER

Requêtes

Visualiser

Rapports

FichierDébutImporterCréerExplorerPartagerModules

MémoMatrice à condensésRelationCodeDocumentCasClassification du casClassification du fichierEnsemble statiqueEnsemble dynamiqueDossier

Codes

Rechercher Projet

Nom	Fichiers	Références	Créé le	Créé par	Modifié le	Modifié par
Attentes - Communication - Passer plus de temps ensemble	0	0	25/08/2026 11:48	ER	25/08/2026 11:48	ER
Représentations hypnose - santé - spectacle	0	0	25/08/2026 11:50	ER	25/08/2026 11:50	ER
	0	0	25/08/2026 11:51	ER	25/08/2026 11:51	ER
	0	0	25/08/2026 11:51	ER	25/08/2026 11:51	ER

ER 6 éléments

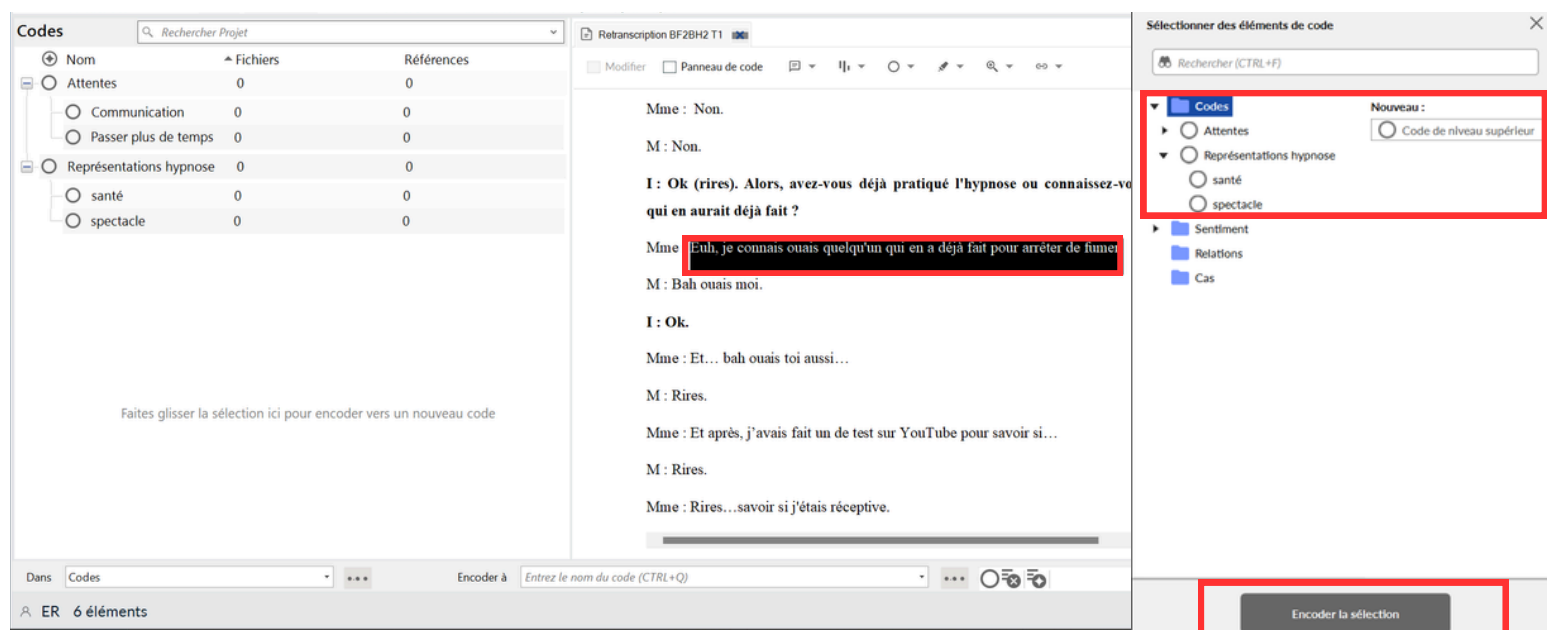
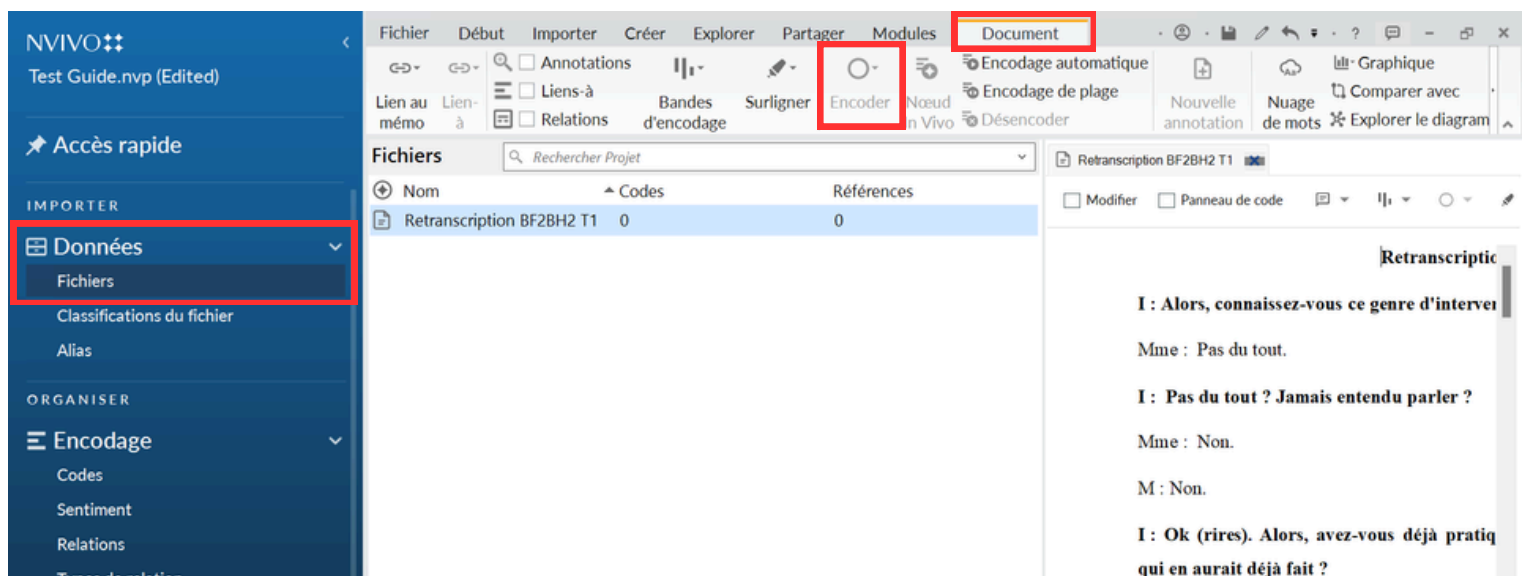
5. Coding your data

5.3 Coding Text

To code a transcript:

- Open the source.
- Select the relevant segment of text.
- Choose Code.
- Select an existing code or create a new one (you can also select the phrase and drag it into the corresponding code)
- Review the coded excerpt.

The same passage can sometimes be assigned to more than one code when it contains several relevant meanings.



5. Coding your data

5.4 Reviewing and Modifying Codes

Coding is an iterative process, as you analyze more interviews, you may can:

- Merge similar codes
- Rename codes
- Split broad codes
- Move codes into different categories
- Remove codes that are no longer useful

Do not hesitate to revise your coding structure, refining the codebook is a normal part of qualitative analysis.

5.5 Coding Consistency and Best Practices

Use clear and consistent coding criteria throughout the analysis. Keep a record of important analytical decisions, especially when: creating a new code, merging codes, changing the meaning of a code; developping a new theme.

A codebook can be later useful for documenting articles for example. You can use board as follow:

Code	Definition	Inclusion criteria	Example
Improved communication	Changes in communication	Statements describing better	"We talk more easily now"

6. Ensuring Analytical Quality

6.1 Reflexivity and Researcher Position

Qualitative analysis involves interpretation. Researchers should therefore remain aware of how their own perspectives, expectations and theoretical assumptions may influence the analysis. Keeping analytical notes or a reflexive journal can help document these reflections.

6.2 Inter-Coder Agreement and Reliability

When multiple researchers code the same dataset, their coding can be compared to discuss similarities and differences. When used, disagreements can be discussed and resolved through a transparent process.

Note: the role of inter-coder agreement depends on the methodological approach adopted. For example Virginia Braun et Clarcke ne recommandent pas forcément l'usage du calcul. Cependant de nombreuses revues peuvent être amenées à le demander.

If necessary in your methodology, **inter-encoder reliability** is typically assessed at the beginning of the coding process to ensure that different researchers understand and apply the codes in the same way. This step allows for adjustments to the coding framework, that is, the thematic tree before coding the entire corpus.



6.Ensuring Analytical Quality

6.2 Inter-Coder Agreement and Reliability

A common practice is to select a subset of the corpus, typically representing **10% to 20%** of the total data.

For example:

- a few complete interviews
- several representative excerpts
- or documents covering different situations within the corpus.



This subset must be sufficiently varied to reflect the diversity of the data being analyzed.

The researchers then code the same subset of data independently, using the same coding scheme. It is important that the coders work without consulting one another during this phase.

NVivo offers a feature called Coding Comparison Query that allows you to compare coding done by different users and calculate agreement metrics.

Compare coding between two coders

- 1.Go to the Query tab.
- 2.Click on Coding Comparison Query.
- 3.Select the two users whose coding you want to compare.
- 4.Choose the sources to analyze (for example, interviews).
- 5.Select the codes (nodes) to compare.
- 6.Run the query.
- 7.NVivo then generates a table displaying the results of the comparison.

6.Ensuring Analytical Quality

6.2 Inter-Coder Agreement and Reliability

Comparing Coding with More Than Two Coders

NVivo's Coding Comparison Query function compares only two coders at a time. When more than two researchers are involved in the coding process, a different approach is therefore necessary.

Pairwise comparisons

The solution is to perform several pairwise comparisons:

Coder A vs. Coder B

Coder A vs. Coder C

Coder B vs. Coder C, etc.

The resulting Kappa coefficients can then be compared or averaged to obtain an overall estimate of coding reliability.

Metrics Calculated by NVivo

The coding comparison yields two main metrics.

- **Percentage of agreement:** This represents the proportion of segments for which both coders applied the same codes. It is calculated as: $\text{number of agreements} / \text{total number of units analyzed}$. This metric provides a simple estimate of the level of consistency between coders.
- **Cohen's Kappa coefficient:** Cohen's Kappa coefficient, which measures agreement between two coders while accounting for agreement that might occur by chance. Generally used for scientific articles. The Kappa coefficient typically ranges from 0 to 1. ***A Kappa coefficient greater than 0.70 is generally considered acceptable in the scientific literature.***

6.Ensuring Analytical Quality

6.2 Inter-Coder Agreement and Reliability

Interpreting the Results

- A low Kappa coefficient does not necessarily mean that the coding is incorrect. It may indicate: that the code definitions are not clear enough that coders interpret certain data differently that the coding scheme needs to be adjusted.

In this case, it will be necessary to discuss coding discrepancies. This step allows you to: identify poorly defined codes, clarify certain categories, modify, merge or remove codes if necessary, and improve the Kappa coefficient. Coding comparison should therefore be viewed as a tool for improving the coding grid and the consistency of the analysis.

The objective is not simply to obtain identical coding, but to ensure that analytical decisions are clear, coherent and justified.

Coding the Rest of the Corpus

Once the coding framework has been finalized and its reliability deemed satisfactory, researchers can begin coding the entire corpus. Depending on the project, the data may then be coded by a single researcher or distributed among several coders.



7. Exploring and Visualizing Your Data

7.1 Coding Queries

Queries can help you explore how your data have been coded, they can be used to:

- Retrieve all excerpts associated with a code
- Examine relationships between codes
- Explore patterns across participants

7.2 Matrix Coding Queries

Matrix coding can be useful for comparing coding patterns across different groups or characteristics.

For example:

Rows: Themes

Columns: Study groups

This can help identify differences or similarities in the distribution of coded content.

Important: Frequency differences should be interpreted in relation to the qualitative context and should not automatically be treated as statistical differences.



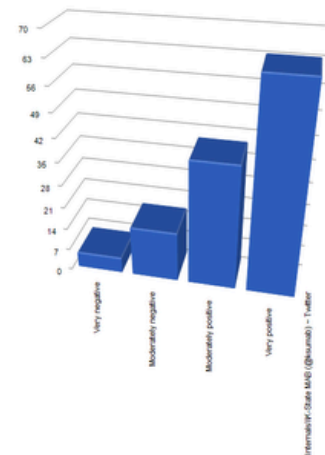
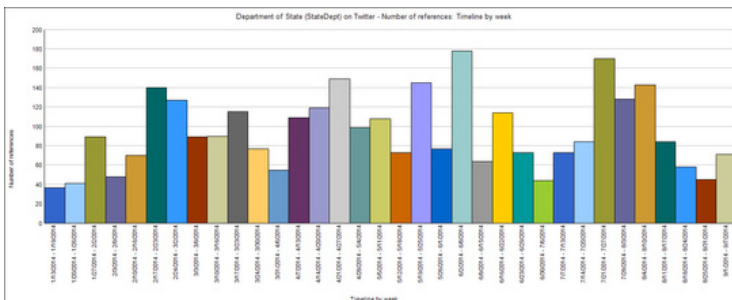
7. Exploring and Visualizing Your Data

7.3 Charts and Visualizations

What ? & Why ?

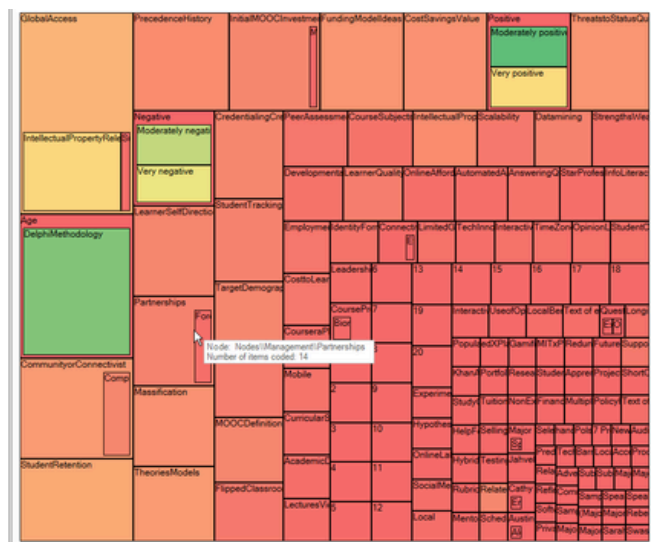
Diagrams and charts

- These visualizations can show, for example: the distribution of codes within the data the frequency of certain themes comparisons between groups of participants.



Visualizing Relationships Between Codes

- These visualizations can show, for example: which codes frequently appear together which sources are associated with certain themes how themes are distributed across the corpus. These tools can help identify patterns in the data and deepen the analysis.



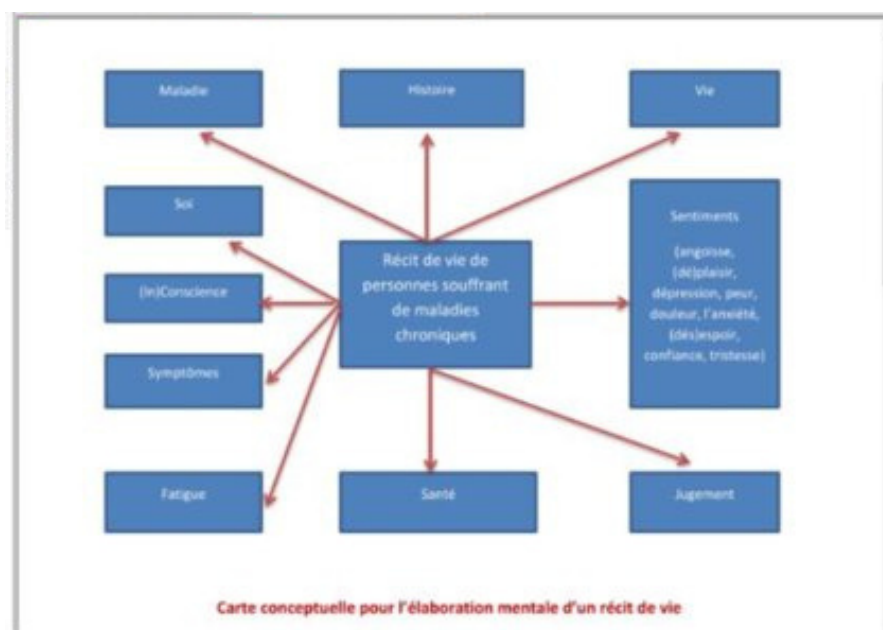
7. Exploring and Visualizing Your Data

7.3 Charts and Visualizations

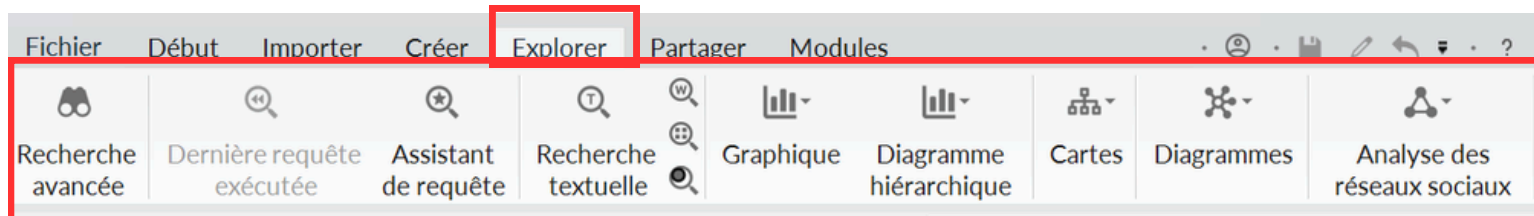
What ? & Why ?

Concept maps and project maps

- Concept maps provide a visual representation of the relationships between different elements of a project, such as: themes, categories, concepts under analysis.



How ?

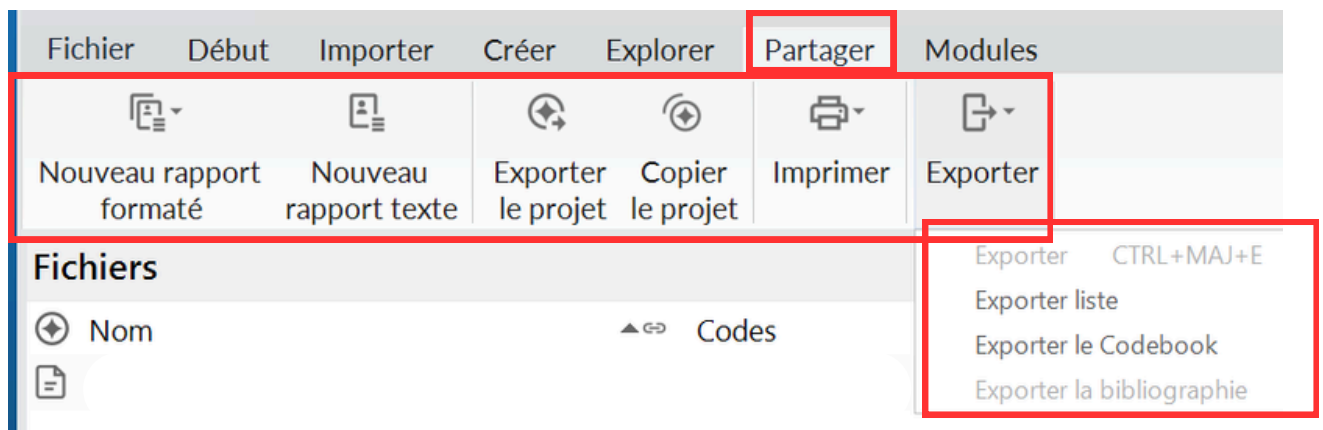


8. Exporting and Reporting Results

8.1 Exporting Coded Data

NVivo allows you to export coded excerpts and other project information. Depending on your needs, you may export:

- Coded excerpts
- Node summaries
- Coding reports
- Query results
- Tables
- Visualizations



9. Common Mistakes

- **I cannot find my imported files**

→ Check the Sources section and verify that the files were imported into the correct folder.

- **I accidentally coded the wrong passage**

→ Select the relevant coding and remove or modify the coding assignment.

- **I have created too many similar codes**

→ Review your code list and consider merging codes that represent the same underlying concept.

- **My thematic tree is becoming too complicated**

→ Step back from individual codes and consider the broader patterns emerging from the dataset.

- **My results are mostly frequencies**

→ Remember that thematic analysis is not simply a counting exercise. Return to the original excerpts and interpret their meaning in context. When in doubt, return to the research question and the original data.

It's your turn !

10. References